leadership at the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) summits. Like the other BRICS, China's financial statecraft operates in the context of the leadership's view of China as a regional power. For his part, Xi reportedly "aspires to increase China's power and influence . . . to give it a dominant role in Asia and the Western Pacific—at the cost of U.S. ascendancy," but strongly prefers the approach of "pushing towards the bottom-line without breaking it."[28]

As discussed in Chapter 3, Xi also launched the One Belt, One Road (OBOR) initiative in 2013 to expand China's presence both through the ocean and on land to connect the country throughout the Eurasia continent and beyond. The fact that initiatives such as OBOR, the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), and the NDB emerged in the years when China's "going out" strategy and loans and investments are facing default risk and debtor insolvency[29] demonstrates that China's financial statecraft intentions go beyond infrastructure funding and regional connectivity. Multilateral initiatives and positive enticement are ways to manage the risks of China's growing global presence where anti-Chinese sentiment and securing China's national interests are at stake.[30]

In sum, despite political regime changes and throughout the dramatic ups and downs of the nation in China's seventy-year postwar history, the Chinese leadership maintained two fundamental aspirations as important parts of China's foreign policy identity. First, China is a great nation with a desire to contribute to global governance on its own terms. Second, China is a developing country that has already reached upper-middle-income status and whose interests also align with the unfairly treated parts of the world that have a legacy of colonization. Why is China interested in collaborating with BRICS members and engaging in collective financial statecraft, given that it possesses sufficient financial capability to influence global governance single-handedly? Its motives spring from five sources, discussed next.

Aversion to the Domination of Western Liberal Values in Global Financial Governance

The first source of China's motivation derives from the nation's frustration with the predominance of Western liberal norms, rules, and strategies of global financial governance. China also shares with other BRICS leaders an